

Truth and logic



Analytic philosophy offered the prospect of a more scientific method of examining philosophical arguments. Translating them into a series of logical propositions, however, can be problematic. Before their validity can be tested, the sometimes flowery and convoluted language of philosophers must be presented as simply as possible, but the concepts of philosophy are frequently not as clear-cut as those in a mathematical or logical proposition and, unlike numbers and symbols, words and phrases present problems of meaning, so it is sometimes impossible to establish the truth of a statement. Seemingly similar statements in the same logical form, may have very

different logical implications. For example, if we say, 'The King of Spain is bald', the meaning is clear and we can check the facts to establish empirically if it is true or false. However, the statement 'The King of France is bald' has exactly the same logical form, and an obvious meaning, but is it true or false? There *is* no King of France, so how can we check? Despite its valid logical form, such a statement may have no meaning at all.